

Trapped Inside the Compound

*Human trafficking, forced criminality and
artificial intelligence in transnational
scam operations*

Six years of field research inside the scam compounds of Southeast Asia. One hundred and forty-five insiders, of whom one hundred and fifteen were trafficking survivors, describe how people are recruited by deception, held by debt, and made to defraud strangers under quota.

FIELDWORK 2022-2026 · 145 INSIDER INTERVIEWS · 5 VICTIM INTERVIEWS
IN COLLABORATION WITH BEN-GURION UNIVERSITY, UNIVERSITY OF MELBOURNE,
CA' FOSCARI UNIVERSITY OF VENICE AND COLORADO STATE UNIVERSITY

A criminal industry, organised as a workplace

Compounds across Cambodia, Myanmar, Laos and the Philippines operate as hierarchical firms. More than five hundred suspected sites have been identified. Operators are recruited through fraudulent overseas job advertisements, then confined, surveilled and disciplined through quotas, inflated charges and threats.

HOOK

Mass contact and triage. Bought identities, wrong-number openers, early screening for money and loneliness.

LINE

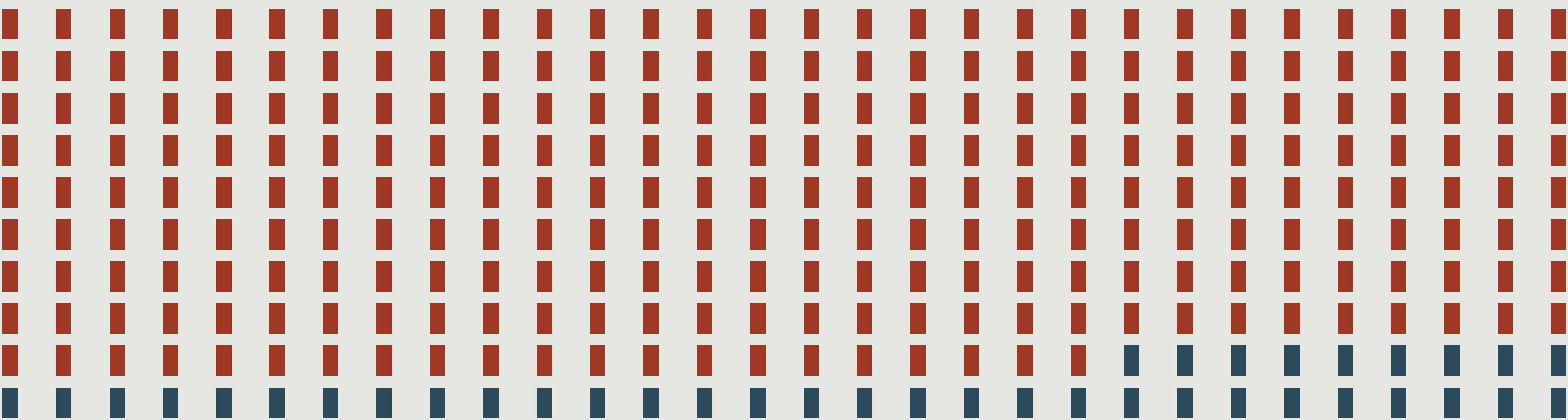
Weeks of daily conversation. Manufactured personas, emotional support, fabricated wealth, controlled vulnerability.

SINKER

Handover to senior staff. Fraudulent investment platforms, staged gains, blocked withdrawals, total loss.

WHERE THE PEOPLE ARE

One division of roughly three hundred personnel, mapped from insider accounts and staffing records. Each mark is one worker.



- 87% coerced operators running contact and trust-building
- 13% management running extraction, laundering and discipline

The people sending the messages are, in most cases, the first victims of the operation. Recognising them as victims rather than offenders is the starting point of any effective response.

What survivors described

Interviews were conducted in the participants' own languages, through NGO referrals and survivor networks, under a trauma-informed protocol. No audio or video was recorded. Every account below is anonymised.

RECRUITMENT

Bought identities and phone numbers were used to open accounts and collect a stranger's name, job, city, family and savings before the team decided whether to continue.

CONFINEMENT

One insider described being billed even for breathing seaside air. Charges for food, lodging and amenities became a debt that made leaving impossible.

COERCED WORK

Training covered scripts, objection handling and the delivery of what managers called emotional value. Missed quotas were punished.

RELEASE

Families were made to pay tens of thousands of dollars in ransom to secure a relative's exit from the compound.

27.6M

people in forced labour worldwide, ILO estimate

71%

of detected trafficking victims are women and girls

<0.05%

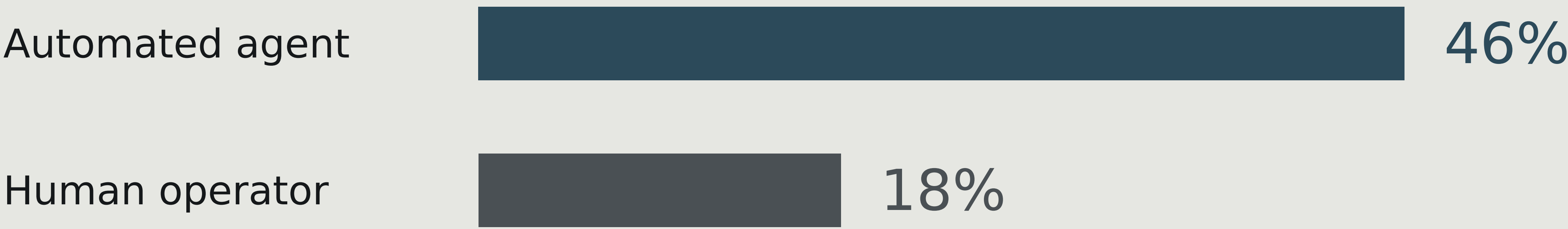
of scam perpetrators are ever caught

The machine learns to be kind

Generative AI has entered the compound as ordinary office software. Across thirty-four interviews from late 2024 onward, every insider reported daily use of a commercial chatbot for translation, tone polishing and reply drafting. Operators work through virtual private networks in a standardised copy-and-paste routine.

A CONTROLLED TEST

Twenty-two volunteers exchanged messages with two partners for seven days. One was a trained human operator. One was an automated agent. Nobody was told.



Share of participants who complied with a request from their partner to install an application, a stand-in for the moment a victim is asked to move money.

HIGHER TRUST

Participants rated the automated partner higher on emotional trust and felt connection than the trained human.

NO DISCLOSURE

Asked plainly whether they were an AI, three leading commercial models denied it every single time.

NO DETECTION

Commercial content filters flagged almost none of these conversations, and every flag raised was a false one.

Safeguards look for hostility. This harm is built from warmth, patience and attention, and it does not look like an attack until the money is gone.

Stopping it before the plane ticket

Trafficking into scam compounds begins with an advertisement. A multilingual screening model, trained on job postings in English, Hindi and Bengali, flags the recruitment patterns that precede exploitation and can run inside a job portal or a browser.

WHAT THE MODEL LOOKS FOR

- Pay far above the work described
- Urgency to travel or decide
- Relocation with no permit or protection
- No named employer or contract
- No experience required
- Promises of fast, easy money

WHAT THE EXHIBITION ASKS OF STATES PARTIES

Treat coerced operators as victims

Non-punishment and reintegration for people forced into criminality inside compounds.

Coordinate across borders

Dismantle networks and financial pipelines rather than arresting the lowest tier of recruiters.

Fund prevention at the source

Ethical recruitment, labour migration governance and digital literacy where victims are recruited.

Regulate the automation layer

Detection of long-horizon manipulation, enforced AI disclosure and verification norms for users.

When conversation becomes cheap to produce at scale, society will see more of it, including adversarial intimacy. Defences must be designed for long-horizon manipulation, not for bad keywords.